

Pedestrian Advisory Committee

May 8, 2019

7:00 PM Brookline Town Hall

Meeting Minutes

(Note-taker: Ali Pincus-Jacobs)

Committee Members in Attendance: Adelaide Ketchum, Frank Caro, David Trevvett, Jane Ross, Ali Pincus-Jacobs, Bob Sloane

Others in Attendance: Ed Krafcik (Soofa), Dan Schwartz (Soofa), Scott Englander

1. Topics not on the agenda
 - a. Crowdfunding Campaign was run to raise money to give the book “Walkable City Rules” to town leaders – including Pedestrian Advisory Committee. Meant to be thought provoking and informative to help leaders understand walkability issues.
 - b. Decision to change ongoing agenda item to “Public Comment on Items Not on the Agenda” instead of listing “Topics not on the agenda”. This is in line with what the Transportation Board includes on their agenda.
2. Review of minutes of April meeting
 - a. Approval of April meeting minutes will be deferred until next meeting.
3. Alternate designs for Longwood-Harvard Intersection Improvements
 - a. Option 1 – challenging for larger trucks and emergency vehicles to get by. Only two vehicle lanes on Longwood. Strong for pedestrians.
 - b. Option 2 – Retains 3 vehicle lanes on Longwood. But longer, skewed crosswalks for pedestrians
 - c. Option 3 – apex ramp may not be best option for handicapped people. Benefit is that it straightens and decreases the overall length of the crosswalks from Option 2, but not as much as Option 1.
 - d. Option 4 – proposed by Jonathan Kapust prior to the meeting - larger trucks would have to leave their travel lane to make turns, as with Option 1. Trading a bump out for a refuge island on Harvard. How much does this burden vehicles?
 - e. Committee opinion – important to keep crosswalks close to the pedestrians’ desired path of travel (since that is where they tend to go anyway). Questioning whether or not any of these options improve the crossing of Longwood – which tends to be the more challenging crossing in this area due to turning cars. Pedestrian refuge on Harvard could be helpful to protect pedestrians from cars turning from Longwood left onto Harvard.
 - f. Majority of committee is in favor of Option 4 – however, concern about costs and feasibility.
 - g. Some main concerns and questions overall:
 - i. In Option 3 – why don’t they put the bump out on the other side of the street? Maybe because that would cause a loss of parking?
 - ii. Safety of apex ramp?
 - iii. Could you take Option 2 and shift bump out on west side of Harvard further south to make the crosswalk perpendicular? This would be a better scenario.
 - h. Committee will vote to authorize David to write to the Transportation Board with our preferences – stating that Jonathan’s option is our first choice and Option 2 with changes is our second choice. Committee voted to authorize this.
4. Soofa Signs – outdoor electronic kiosks for Brookline – presentation and discussion, including any specific recommendations for sign locations during potential pilot. *Guest: Ed Krafcik from Soofa - Company web site: <http://www.soofa.co/>*

- a. Soofa contacted Brookline after seeing an article about our e-scooter pilot. Brought to the attention of Brookline Economic Development office and the person who manages the 3 sided bulletin boards/arts commission.
- b. Role of pedestrian advisory committee is to evaluate if this is good for pedestrians, brainstorm locations and important content, bring up issues or concerns and share this with Economic Development office.
- c. Soofa started out of the MIT Media Lab – started with a solar power park bench for charging devices. Now in many cities and towns across country. Evolved to help cities and towns with engagement. Product is digital bulletin board with citizen content.
- d. Soofa and scooters – in places like Atlanta with lots of scooters, Soofa signs began to be a place where people would line up scooters. Some cities are moving towards scooter “corrals” instead of scooters everywhere.
- e. Conversation evolved to how the Soofa product could help with citizen communication and help streamline the physical bulletin board posting process.
- f. Signs have been in Boston for over a year. Key is to place the signs in walkable, mixed use locations like Brookline’s commercial areas. Signs are best used to communicate information that is “here and now” – content comes from community groups and business community. Revenue comes from local businesses. Businesses can pay for guaranteed, longer air time on the signs, or posting outside of your immediate neighborhood – sponsored content. Town can always share content for free – they keep 20% of air time to use how they want. Useful for town to share information, meetings, events, etc...
- g. Placement is very important – so that they stay useful but not overwhelming.
- h. Soofa is prototyping “neighborhood explore” page so you could see the content running on a specific sign from your computer or phone.
- i. Question – are signs an obstruction for pedestrians? Soofa signs are narrow and could be placed where there is sufficient room.
- j. Frank felt he needed to stop, go close to it and read it to really read the content. Small text doesn’t necessarily grab you as you are walking. Where are the captive audiences? Bus stop? T stops?
- k. Committee sees natural use cases for the Soofa sign – for example, Friends of a Park having a community day. Also for public information – example reminder of scooters to not go on sidewalks (this was done in Atlanta).
- l. Signs are placed logically so that you are likely to see messages multiple times during your walk/path so that it becomes an impactful message that you see multiple times.
- m. Committee Concern: Freestanding sign on sidewalk space... but more enthusiastic for use in t stops. How would this impact the visually impaired pedestrian? Soofa has worked closely with disability commission in Boston on their placement of signs.
- n. Challenge in Brookline is finding the wide enough sidewalks. What are parameters for a “good” spot for a Soofa sign? Sun, space, pedestrian traffic flow (sensor inside can count pedestrian traffic flow – can be shared with town, can also be used to help determine best place to place signs, they sell by impression, so they need this data), commercial areas, can’t install on brick.
- o. How is content regulated? Soofa monitors content and does not allow political content, hate speech, etc... would town have say or ability to be a part of oversight? Everything posted is reviewed by a real person in the Soofa office in Cambridge.
- p. Soofa is currently working with Boston and Atlanta. In Boston they work with Mayor’s Office of New Urban Mechanics and the Public Improvement Commission. In Atlanta, they

have a point person in the city. What is the best governance structure in Brookline? Who is the point person in the town?

- q. Committee's role right now is information gathering to pass along questions, feedback, concerns and suggestions to Todd Kirrane, Kara Brewton and others.

5. Update on Brookline Hills MBTA station redesign (as part of high school expansion) *Guest: Scott Englander, TMM Precinct 6, which includes this station*

- a. In exchange for being able to build a new building at 111 Cypress that goes over the tracks, town will be spending \$\$ to help redo Brookline Hills station. Includes raising the platform for level boarding.
- b. Residents and commuters wanted to be able to share feedback and give input on the design. 3200 boardings each day (2014 – likely gone up). Their feedback and comments on original design have been incorporated into design being presented today.
- c. Longer platform will accommodate 3-car trains. Some parking and fences removed from original design to create small plaza. Planned egress from station platform onto Brington Road (main entrance on Tappan St. side). Includes elevator entrance into school and steps entrance, also path that continues on to Cypress. Landscaping and design of plaza not yet worked out.
- d. Scott and others propose additional design changes:
 - i. Re: Cross walk outside of the station – raised crossing across Tappan to also be a traffic calming element. Recommendation for it to be even wider to accommodate more pedestrian pathways.
 - ii. Remove 5 additional parking spots to expand plaza at station. Previously some parking had to be retained for teacher parking.
 - iii. In latest design track is raised up for level boarding. Crossing only at either end... but also likely everywhere. Surface between rails should be paved to accommodate this. Uneven surface is bigger safety hazard.
 - iv. Current design has small shelters with little seating for waiting. Suggestion is also make some of the platform that is under the building include seating since people will likely wait there to get out of the rain/snow.
 - v. Sidewalk along station side of Tappan is broken up by driveways into parking areas. Propose continuous sidewalks, as along other Brookline streets, also widened to 10 feet in certain places. Also room to widen it as it goes up towards Cypress..
 - vi. There's an electrical utility pole in the middle of the Tappan south-side sidewalk as it heads up towards Cypress. This pole will evidently be deactivated during construction, so it's an opportunity to move it so that it's less of an obstacle to pedestrians.
 - vii. Bike parking at the station is insufficient – bikes will be used at the high school as long as bike parking is available. Covered bike parking should also be available. Blue Bikes station will be here as well.
 - viii. Change Tappan Street parking from front angle parking with back angle parking (shown to be safer). Unlikely to be done now, but could potentially be done later. Propose designing in a way that does not preclude this later change.
 - ix. Barrier between town parking and MBTA parking due to elevation changes. Recommendation to remove barrier if elevation change isn't significant so people can walk through.
 - x. Access to both sides of tracks is normally very important – increasing access from both sides, increased the "walking" area that people can use to get to the station in a certain

amount of time. Such an arrangement captures more rides and cuts down walk for people. Current design does not provide access from south side of station, but rather just an egress path being designed on the south side – calling it an entrance triggers many new requirements – egress path more likely to come to fruition. Currently-designed path does not follow desire line from station to corner of Cypress/Brington Road. Recommendation that the space between this egress path and the building should prioritize people not vehicles and use “shared space” concepts so drivers are more aware of their surroundings and convey pedestrian priority. Ideally, would design a dignified, safe passageway for pedestrians walk from the station.

- e. What can pedestrian advisory committee do?
 - i. Consider the concerns and recommended elements and make comments to Transportation Board and/or Building Committee.
 - ii. Timeline is moving quickly, so important for parties to weigh in soon.
 - iii. Committee authorizes chair to write comments encouraging the following items to the Transportation Board:
 - 1. Paved track surface
 - 2. Widen crosswalk across Tappan
 - 3. More seating under platform
 - 4. Remove/Move utility pole
 - 5. Expanded plaza (results in lost parking)
 - 6. Continuous sidewalks along Tappan
 - 7. Encouragement of Pedestrian Friendly/Shared Space for egress side path

6. Walk Signal Project – Updates and Next Steps

- 1) Original assignments were missing 14 intersections – 4 are part of Gateway East (being redone so no need for us to check them) and others David is observing.
 - 2) Committee’s observations and data collection are underway and all data should be submitted to David.
 - 3) David created draft report and committee feels that this is a good format to work from.
 - 4) Key is finding both malfunctions and suggestions for improvements/changes. Could lead to discussions on rationale for certain decisions.
 - 5) Malfunctions can be immediately reported to BrookONline by observer.
 - 6) Big issue of pedestrian delays – there are many intersections with Leading Pedestrian Intervals – but also many with pedestrian delays – and it is unclear why or if this is acceptable or not. These decisions should be defended by the town or changed. Committee should make recommendations for changes at specific intersections. Town tends to work intersection by intersection – may be most effective for committee to make recommendations this way as well – or at least in small groups.
 - 7) Committee to continue observations and give feedback on draft report to David.
 - 8) Goal is to create a consistent experience across town using walk signals for pedestrians.
 - 9) Many issues we have found include function of APS equipment – we should share report with disability commission with hope that they will push progress forward.
7. Next Meeting – June 12